choose between being described as ‘Bengali’ or not being able to register to vote. The first option carried the threat of deportation, the second of being forced into one of the refugee camps that had sprung up after the 2012–13 violence in Rakhine. Even worse, the regime then confiscated the ‘White Cards’ that had been the last form of official documentation held by many Rohingyas.[50]

Finally, very few Muslim candidates were allowed to stand for parliament in the 2015 elections[51] (and very few Muslims were eligible to vote).[52] A combination of judgments by the State Electoral Commission[53] and complicity by the major, supposedly multi-confessional, parties means that roughly 5 per cent of the population are now disenfranchised. This is quite deliberate and represents a complete repudiation of the ideals of some who fought for Burmese independence.[54] The current persecution and exclusion of the Rohingyas reflects over forty years of state propaganda designed to ensure that most Burmese now regard them as foreigners and as a threat to Buddhist culture. This narrative, disgracefully, has not been challenged by the democratic opposition party, even though it is led by a winner of the Nobel Peace Prize[54] who is widely praised in the Western media for her commitment to democracy.[56]

As one of the few ethnically Rohingya MPs elected in 2010 put it in an interview with the author:

> Myanmar people are suffering. If people are in hell, I would say Rohingyas are at the bottom of the hell, the worst case, unfortunately. So Myanmar government made the policy by using race or religion, nationality, and then almost all Myanmar ethnic have started hatred against Rohingya and hatred against Islam, and accusing collectively, ‘These people are illegal immigrants.’[57]

This situation is no accident; it has been deliberately manufactured.

Contemporary Politics

Later chapters in this book will cover in detail the shifting political landscape of Burma since independence. In this section the primary goal is to set out some of the complexities of the current situation, in particular with respect to the November 2015 elections. Broadly there are five separate—though overlapping—groups of political actors. These are: